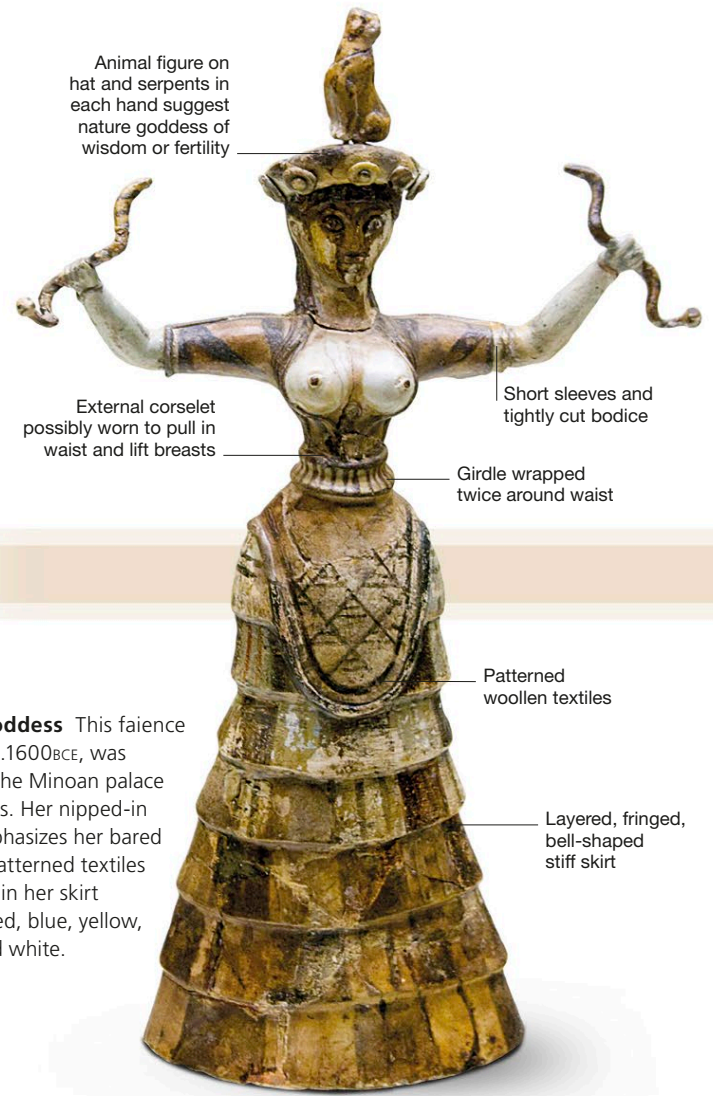


c.3000 – 1500 BCE

MINOAN CULTURE

Centred on the island of Crete, the Minoan civilization was at its height around 1600 BCE; it was advanced and prosperous with widespread trade contacts. Minoan dress from this isolated island society stands out among other ancient European Bronze Age cultures for its cut and stitched body-hugging garments. The small, cinched waist, a key feature of both male and female attire, was emphasized in women by the hats, hairstyles, and embellished sleeves worn above, and the wide, flounced skirts below. Men wore peaked caps, wrapped loincloths around their hips, and showed off their bare torsos – although tunics appeared in the later years of Minoan civilization. The art of weaving complicated, patterned wool cloths flourished on the peaceful, wealthy island and clothing was more elaborate than that of later mainland Greek people. Minoan ideas influenced fashion in Egypt, Mycenae (Ancient Greece), and further afield.



Snake goddess This faience figurine, c.1600 BCE, was found at the Minoan palace of Knossos. Her nipped-in waist emphasizes her bared breasts. Patterned textiles like those in her skirt came in red, blue, yellow, black, and white.

JEWELLERY COLLECTION

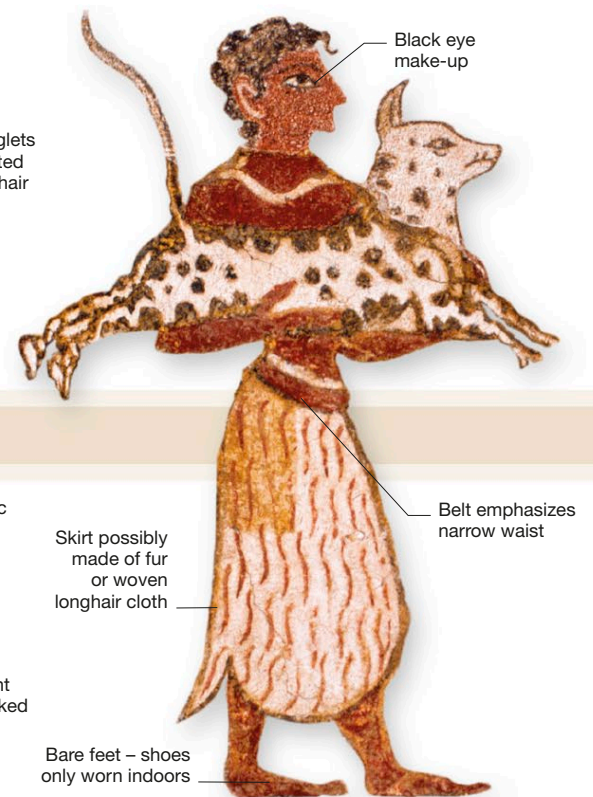


Minoan ear pendant,
c.1700 BCE

Many pieces of jewellery have survived from Minoan culture. The gold pendant shown above is part of a collection known as the Aegina Treasure, thought to be from the island of Aegina. An outer ring in the shape of a two-headed serpent, representing longevity, encircles paired leopards and monkeys. Radiating strings of beads are decorated with sun discs and birds.



Fresco from Thira In a detail from a 16th-century BCE fresco from the island of Thira (also known as Thera or Santorini), two boys fight in the nude, wearing just boxing gloves and a belt. Similarly to women, they use eye make-up and wear their hair in ringlets.



Priest, Hagia Triada sarcophagus Part of a funerary scene painted on a stone coffin found on Crete, c.1400 BCE, this priest offers an animal as a gift to the dead. His clothes are probably made of animal hair and skin.